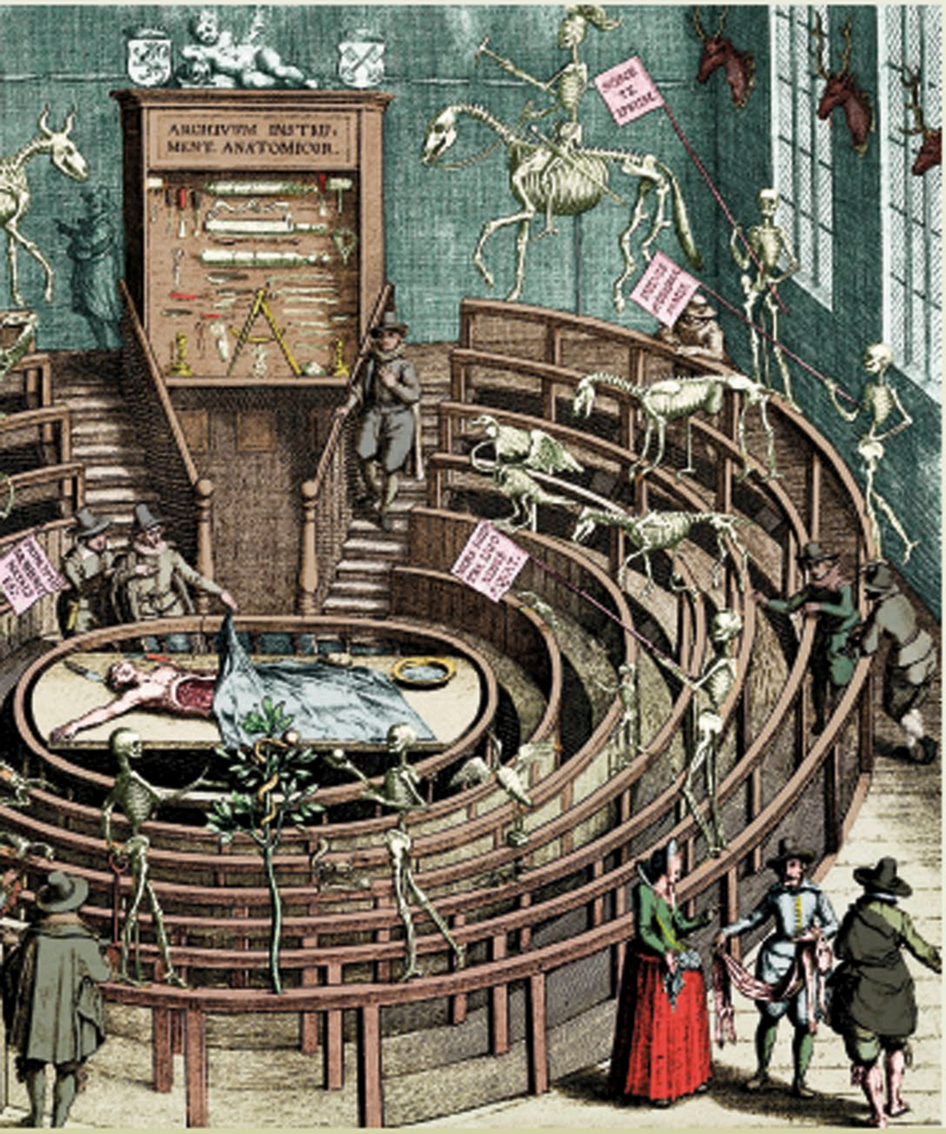
Anatomical theaters

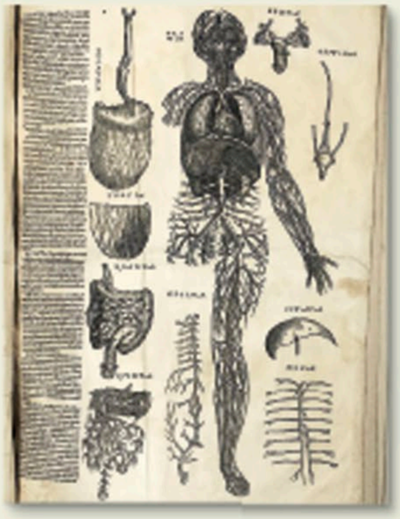
It was the work of Italian doctor Mondino da Luzzi of Bologna University (c 1270–1326) that paved the way for public dissections. He was the first physician since ancient times to teach anatomy to medical students. Eventually, special dissecting rooms, or "theaters," became a feature of European universities. One of the earliest theaters was built at Leiden, in the Netherlands, in 1594.

Skeletons circle a dissection in this fanciful early 17th-century engraving of the anatomy theater at Leiden University.



Vesalius's drawings

Flemish physician and anatomist Andreas Vesalius (1514–1564) studied medicine at the University of Padua, in Italy, and went on to teach there. Realizing that many of the ideas of ancient anatomists had been wrong, he took a closer look at the human body, and produced many superbly accurate drawings. These were published in his famous book *De Humani Corporis Fabrica* (On the Fabric of the Human Body). The quality of Vesalius's anatomical drawings was higher than anything ever seen before. His work was the beginning of modern anatomy.



This page from Vesalius's great atlas of the human body describes various aspects of the nervous system.

Many details shown in Vesalius's drawings of the brain had been ignored by earlier illustrators.

c 1250

Arabic physician Ibn al-Nafisi discovered the pulmonary circulation (the system by which blood reaching the left side of the heart passes first through the lungs).

c 1525

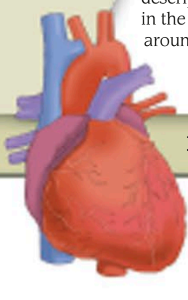
Jacob Berengar of Carpi, Italy, described two hormone-producing organs: the pineal gland and thymus gland. He also gave an account of the structure of the brain.

1543

Vesalius's *De Humani Corporis Fabrica* was published, the first complete and detailed atlas of human anatomy.

1628

English physician William Harvey gave the first correct description of the heart's role in the circulation of blood around the body.



Heart and blood vessels